challenging our young minds. One of these scrapbook-boys went on to become a successful IT entrepreneur, another a high-flying corporate banker.

I do not know what happened to that scrapbook, but Narendra Modi would have featured in it. The BJP was yet to win Gujarat, but his role in the Somnath–Gandhinagar leg of the Yatra meant that, by 1991, he was already being hailed in the press as the 'architect of the BJP's phenomenal growth in Gujarat'.[4] In 1992, less than a month after the demolition of the mosque, with Ayodhya still under curfew—and some BJP leaders in detention—he was being counted as one of the party's next-gen leaders, important enough to be mentioned among the key functionaries who met for an emergency session of the party's national executive in Delhi. The gathered BJP brass, led by senior leaders like future prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee, demanded immediate access to Ram Lalla idols for 'darshan' in the curfew-hit town. They called on the government to allow in devotees to Ayodhya on 26 December 1992 for the yearly 'Pragat Utsav'—a festival commemorating the appearance of the Ram idols in the Babri Masjid in 1948.[5]

Earlier that year, as chief organiser of the BJP's Kanyakumari-to-Kashmir Ekta Yatra, Modi accompanied the then BJP president Murali Manohar Joshi to unfurl the Indian tricolour in Srinagar's Lal Chowk in a symbolic ceremony. The flag-hoisting was preceded by the creation of the eponymously named 'Kesari Vahini' (literally, 'saffron vehicle'), which comprised some 6,00,000 volunteers who had been mobilised from around the country. Its slogan, as Modi told reporters, could not be clearer. 'Article 370 *hatao, atankawad mitao, desh bachao*' (Remove Article 370, wipe out terrorism, save the country).[6] The BJP leaders were airlifted from Jammu to curfewed Srinagar, where they hoisted the tricolour before being flown back. Given the rise of Dr Joshi in the BJP's leadership, what stood out then was Modi's salience as an apparatchik. He was part of the party's tapestry, no matter who headed it. Clearly, in 1990–1993, Modi was a rising star, being noticed for defining party campaigns that presaged some of his signature moves as prime minister two decades later.